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The Manitoba Museum: Bringing the World Home

The Manitoba Museum

Like many public-facing businesses, the Manitoba Museum was forced to make the challenging decision to shut down public programming during the COVID-19 pandemic. Dorota Blumczyńska, CEO of the Manitoba Museum, knows that getting back on track is not as simple as returning to business as usual. Despite tight financial constraints, the Museum has a mandate to bring large world-class exhibits to the Museum's premier exhibition space: Alloway Hall. Dorota's task at hand is to **provide a financially sustainable plan to bring these major exhibitions back to Manitobans** for presentation to the Board of Governors.

Manitobans have been visiting the Manitoba Museum at its location in downtown Winnipeg for more than fifty years, but today's guests would not recognize the original Museum as the same organization. For the Manitoba Museum, simply continuing to document local history would have missed the mark: this Museum is meant to connect Manitobans to the rest of the world. The goal is to bring global experiences, knowledge, and cultures within reach of Manitobans, providing Manitobans with a unique "window to the world". When Dorota joined the organization just under four years ago as CEO, she enthusiastically joined the cause to continue to move the Museum beyond a passive role in historical

documentation and begin to participate in active advocacy and connection for Manitobans and their communities.

Dorota describes the work of the Manitoba Museum as "enabling a dialogue with history" for Manitobans.

> *"We have a real obligation to bring the world to people who may not have the opportunity to leave Manitoba to see it,"* she explains. *"We are focusing our programs and services on the needs of our community. The Museum is an asset that we are activating for the benefit of society."*

Fulfillment of this obligation takes many forms for the 300,000 visitors to the Museum each year. School groups frequently visit the Museum throughout the school year to provide experiential learning around existing school curriculum, in both English and French. Roughly 100,000 school age children visit the Museum annually: this means that almost 50% of the province's school age students visit each year. Dorota describes the Museum as "the largest classroom in the province."

Learning opportunities are not limited to school age children; the Museum also offers professional development programs supporting corporate education about the Truth and Reconciliation Commission of Canada's Calls to Action. Programming for individuals is provided through workshops that allow hands-on experiences for registrants that are guided by local talent. The collections held at the Museum include nearly 3 million artifacts and specimens, largely from local natural history. Exhibits within the facility showcase the ecological history of Manitoba, as well as the cultural history of First Nations, Inuit, and Métis peoples in the province and settlers that came to Manitoba. The organization is an active participant in research into a deeper understanding of our past and present, considering this a central part of the cultural role of the Museum.

The Manitoba Museum does not limit its purview to simply historical records. Although the Museum has an impressive collection of historical artifacts and knowledge, the institution is equally focused on the present and future. The lowest floor of the Museum's facility in Winnipeg is dedicated to the Science Gallery and the Planetarium. The major themes of these exhibits are environmental science, space,

mechanics, and engineering. The Science Gallery is an interactive experience which encourages visitors to use creativity and imagination to experiment and learn by doing.

For Dorota and her team, making this vision a reality for the organization comes with practical challenges. The Manitoba Museum is a not-for-profit, charitable organization, differentiating it from many parallel, but provincially run museums in other regions. Uniquely, the Manitoba Museum stands on its own, governed by a Board of Governors. It is an independent organization in all aspects of its work: determining strategic priorities, fulfilling its mandate, and managing ongoing operations. Finding the funding to support the operations of the Museum has required a mixed revenue model. The Museum's provincial operating grant comprises 51% of revenues, while the remainder consists of admission fees, memberships, donations, grants from foundations, corporate sponsorships, facility rentals, professional development programming, and gift shop sales.

Grant Funding

Grant funding makes up the most significant portion of the Museum's revenues and is largely provided by the Government of Manitoba. Government support has remained steady since 2008, with no annual, indexed increases in the past 17 years. Accounting for inflation, the result is that the Government of Manitoba has effectively divested nearly 40% of financial support from the Manitoba Museum (based on CPI rates between 2008 – 2023). This has forced the Museum, year over year, to seek other sources of revenue to make up the difference.

Admission Fees

Admission to areas of the Manitoba Museum is priced as follows:

Attractions	Adult (18-64)	Senior (65+)	Youth (3-17) or with Student ID	Children under 3	Museum Members	Indigenous Peoples
Museum Galleries	$17.00	$15.00	$10.00	FREE	FREE	FREE
Planetarium	$10.50	$8.50	$7.00	FREE	FREE	FREE
Science Gallery	$10.50	$8.50	$7.00	FREE	FREE	FREE
Bundle and save! All 3 Attractions	$27.00	$24.00	$19.00	FREE	FREE	FREE

The Museum revaluates admission pricing annually and is currently piloting a one-price, all attractions model.

The Museum offers free admission for Indigenous Peoples (First Nations, Inuit, and Métis). This is based on the Museum's commitment to sharing responsibility for Indigenous ancestral belongings and stories. The Museum acknowledges past harms and is dedicated to reconciliation through reconnection and healing by providing a space for community reflection. Indigenous complimentary admission honours this commitment by ensuring accessibility and mutual respect for these traditional lands.

The Museum also participates in the CANOO program, granting new Canadian citizens free general admission to over 1,400 cultural institutions across Canada. In 2024, 4,684 new Canadians were welcomed by the Museum with free admission. Similarly, the Manitoba Museum supports the Canadian Forces Appreciation Program, offering Canadian Forces members a 15% discount on admission. These programs highlight the Museum's dedication to inclusivity and providing opportunities for all to engage with Manitoba's stories.

The Manitoba Museum offers a yearly membership program as follows:

Family	Two adults (18+) and three youth (3-17)	$140.70
Adult Pair	Two people (18-64)	$96.60
Senior Pair	Two people (65+)	$79.80
Adult	One person (18-64)	$48.30
Senior	One person (65+)	$39.90
Youth	One person (3-17)	$33.60
Organization	One business (includes 8 member cards)	$386.40

Membership Benefits

- **Unlimited general admission** to the Museum Galleries, Planetarium, and Science Gallery!
- **Early-bird ticket access and special discounted pricing** on public programs, course registrations, and temporary exhibitions. Click here to see what's on!
- 10% off at the **Museum Shop**. Visit the Shop!
- **Discounts at local restaurants and businesses** in Winnipeg's Exchange District, such as Colosimo Coffee Roasters, Across the Board Game Café, Nonsuch Brewing Co., and more!
- **Subscription** to the monthly *Member Insider* e-newsletter!
- **Free or discounted admission** to 30+ science centres and museums across Canada through CASC and ANHMC! *
- **Discounted memberships at local organizations**: Fort Whyte Alive (15%), Oak Hammock Marsh (10%), Children's Museum (10%), WAG-Qaumajuq ($10 off a Friend Plus or Partner WAG-Qaumajuq membership), and Canadian Museum for Human Rights (10%)! *
- **Voting Privileges** at our Annual General Meeting (members 18 years & older)
- And more...!

Maintaining accessibility to the Museum is a priority, therefore any suggestion of admission fee increases would require a mitigation strategy to ensure that access to the Museum is not limited further by socioeconomic status. Events with complimentary admission, such as Orange Shirt Days, in honour of the National Day for Truth and Reconciliation, have attracted many visitors. During the three days of special programming in 2024, during which admission was complimentary, nearly 10,000 visitors came to the Manitoba Museum. Dorota and her team are interested in re-evaluating the admission fees model to identify better ways to support un-barriered access for Manitobans.

As part of Dorota's proposal, the Board would like a recommendation on a fee structure during blockbuster exhibitions. Should regular admission include access to blockbuster exhibitions? Or should blockbuster exhibitions have their own ticket sales? If so, should the tickets be discounted with general admission to the Museum? Any sustainable plan that removes economic barriers for visitors to the Museum would be looked upon favorably by the Board and the community.

Fundraising

Fundraising within Manitoba's corporate community has historically been successful, as the Museum has built longstanding relationships with corporate community members. Sponsorship offers a unique opportunity for corporations to align their brands with the Museum's mission of making a space for community engagement, education, and innovation. By partnering with the Museum, sponsors gain visibility, association with a trusted cultural institution, and the chance to engage directly with diverse audiences.

Post-pandemic, maintaining ongoing sponsorship relationships has become more difficult as several key corporate head offices have either relocated out of Manitoba or closed. National corporations without local offices in Manitoba are less likely to provide corporate sponsorship in local communities. Furthermore, corporate sponsors have shifted their priorities in recent years, seeking organizations which have significant public reach and offer on-the-ground employee engagement opportunities for their own teams.

Organizations seeking sponsorship within Manitoba are facing increased competition for limited funds, as more charitable organizations have developed in the province to meet growing community needs. The Museum must now explore innovative fundraising strategies, cultivate relationships with new corporate partners, and appeal to a broader network of donors to ensure the sustainability of its mission. These efforts are critical to maintaining the Museum's role as a cornerstone of cultural, educational, and scientific enrichment for Manitoba and beyond.

Rentals

The Manitoba Museum has a variety of rental spaces available for community or corporate events, with weddings comprising a significant portion of the rental revenue. Rentals of the facilities can include the Museum Galleries, the Planetarium, the Science Gallery, or event spaces including Festival Hall or Alloway Hall. As the rentals program uses the Museum's publicly accessible spaces, scheduling rentals must be balanced with ensuring access to the facilities and exhibits for Manitobans.

Manitoba Museum Shop

Within the walls of the Manitoba Museum, the gift shop offers an opportunity to create additional revenue to support Museum operations via retail sales. The Manitoba Museum Shop offers products that are matched thematically to the diverse galleries, as well as a selection of Manitoba-made items. Particularly featured are the works of Indigenous artists, including mugs, jewelry, postcards, and more. During times when the Museum is hosting a temporary exhibition, the increase in visitors to the site represents an opportunity to capture additional sales. However, the Museum Shop has not generated enough profit to contribute meaningfully to the Museum's bottom line.

Planned to open in late 2025, a Museum Shop Café is currently being constructed to enhance the presence of the Shop and expand the services available for visitors to the Museum. Ensuring the success of this new venture would be beneficial for the Manitoba Museum as well as Manitobans. Is there an opportunity to further develop the Shop and Café to provide stronger financial support for the Museum?

Alloway Hall

Alloway Hall is the Manitoba Museum's largest event space, designed to host large-scale, time-limited exhibitions. These temporary "blockbuster" exhibitions require a substantial financial investment to bring into the facility and are generally planned to run for approximately four months. Alloway Hall was expanded from a smaller footprint into nearly 10,000 square feet of functional space in 2017 to enable the Museum to bring large exhibitions to Manitoba which would otherwise have no suitable venue. The finished space is a multi-functional hall which has flexible lighting options, 13' tall windows, vaulted ceilings, and can host 500 people at a seated dinner, making it an excellent rental option for large events in the community.

Funding for this expansion was largely provided through government grants. The Government of Manitoba provided $3.8 million, the Government of Canada provided $1 million, and a charitable organization called The Winnipeg Foundation provided $0.5 million to finance the expansion cost. Government funding was provided with the understanding that the Alloway Hall space would be used to bring experiences and opportunities to Manitobans in the form of blockbuster exhibitions. Given these circumstances, the Manitoba Museum Board and management see the return of blockbuster exhibitions as mandatory to fulfill the obligation they accepted when funding was granted for the hall.

Blockbuster Exhibitions

Finding a way to continue hosting blockbuster exhibitions in a financially sustainable way is considered critical by the Manitoba Museum's leadership. In addition to meeting the expectations from government funding, the ability to host world class exhibitions is central to the goals of the organization: to bring the world to Manitobans. These exhibitions offer transformative experiences that connect Manitobans with contemporary knowledge and research from every corner of the globe. Unfortunately, recent blockbuster exhibitions hosted in Alloway Hall have not provided the financial returns that the organization needs to continue with this type of programming.

Prior to COVID-19 closures in 2020, the Manitoba Museum had arranged and paid for their next blockbuster exhibition, when they were unexpectedly forced to delay due to the pandemic control measures. Finally, in summer of 2022, the Manitoba Museum hosted “Ultimate Dinosaurs”, on loan from the Science Museum of Minnesota. This blockbuster exhibition introduced dinosaurs from South America, Africa, and Madagascar to Manitobans. The dinosaur exhibition was chosen as it brought knowledge, specimens, and experiences that would not normally be available in Manitoba. However, in the spring of 2022, the RBC Convention Centre in Winnipeg hosted “Jurassic Quest”, a competing dinosaur exhibition. Concurrently with the Manitoba Museum’s “Ultimate Dinosaurs” exhibition, the Assiniboine Park Zoo in Winnipeg also hosted their own dinosaur-themed event, which ran all summer and featured animatronic dinosaurs. With this competition and market saturation, the Museum’s “Ultimate Dinosaurs” exhibition ticket sales underperformed. Budget expectations were not met, and the exhibition resulted in an overall financial loss of nearly $300,000.

Preparation for an exhibition of this scale in Alloway Hall requires advance arrangements with the vendors of the travelling exhibitions. Selection of the exhibitions to invest in typically takes place two to four years in advance and must be based on the needs and interests of Manitobans, including educational institutions as well as the public. The up-front cost to rent an exhibition of this scale for four months ranges, however it generally falls between $400,000 and $600,000.

A breakdown of this cost estimate includes the following:

- Exhibition fees averaged $231,000 over the last four major exhibitions
- Transportation/shipping costs averaged $27,500 over the last three exhibitions
- Installation and removal costs were found to average $24,500 over the last three exhibitions
- Preparation costs including site preparation, equipment rental, and storage costs averaged $18,800 over the last four exhibitions

as well as additional staffing and other miscellaneous costs.

Exhibitions are crated for transportation and require an involved shipping process as they are made up of large and valuable items. Obtaining clearance for high value artifacts to cross borders requires substantial advance planning. Once the exhibition is received at the Manitoba Museum, set-up of the exhibition

takes three to four weeks. Staffing requirements are heavier for the Museum to operate the special exhibition, as there is a need for additional security and staffing for the duration of the run time.

During the exhibition set up, run time, and disassembly (an additional three to four weeks after the exhibition closure), the space occupied by the exhibition cannot be used for rental income. Before the Manitoba Museum had fully developed the rental program, special exhibitions were held approximately once per year. To mitigate the impact of lost rental income and ease the expense of these large investments, hosting blockbuster exhibitions has had to happen less frequently in recent years. Choosing the appropriate time to host an exhibition is a critical decision for the Manitoba Museum team, as winter exhibitions have historically seen fewer visitors, but also interfere less with wedding rental income which is more heavily weighted toward summer. The next blockbuster exhibitions are tentatively set for winter of 2026-2027, winter of 2027-2028, and summer of 2030; these dates are not yet locked in with vendor agreements.

Visitor Feedback

The Manitoba Museum proactively collects feedback from visitors, which is used to guide decisions about programming and exhibitions for the future. Serving Manitobans requires listening to Manitobans which is why the Museum leadership has encouraged regular visitor surveys to gauge current successes and opportunities. Appendix E provides additional details of past survey results. Day-to-day, plenty of positive feedback can be found, proving to the dedicated team at the Manitoba Museum that their efforts have real impact:

> *"One of the best museums I have ever visited. If you live in Winnipeg, you should visit this place. Highly recommended. Please reserve enough time for the visit because a lot of things to see. So keep more time to explore the place. Really worthy."*
> *- Nusrat Jahan*

> *"This museum is packed with history in every corner! Every time you turn around, there's something new to explore from the past. I loved how each section felt like a little adventure—there's so much to learn, from Manitoba's natural history to the stories of the people who lived here. It's such a fun*

and engaging experience. Definitely worth the visit if you enjoy diving into history."
-Honey Grace Leopando

"Excellent place, I am not a museum lover, but this place left me amazed, totally recommended 10/10 of everything"
- Myriam Carrasco

"This museum is a must see for Winnipeg visitors! But you better give yourself at least 3-4 hours minimum to see most of it. You can easily spend all day if you take in all the exhibits. One of the best museums I've visited!"
- John Durham

Planning for the Future

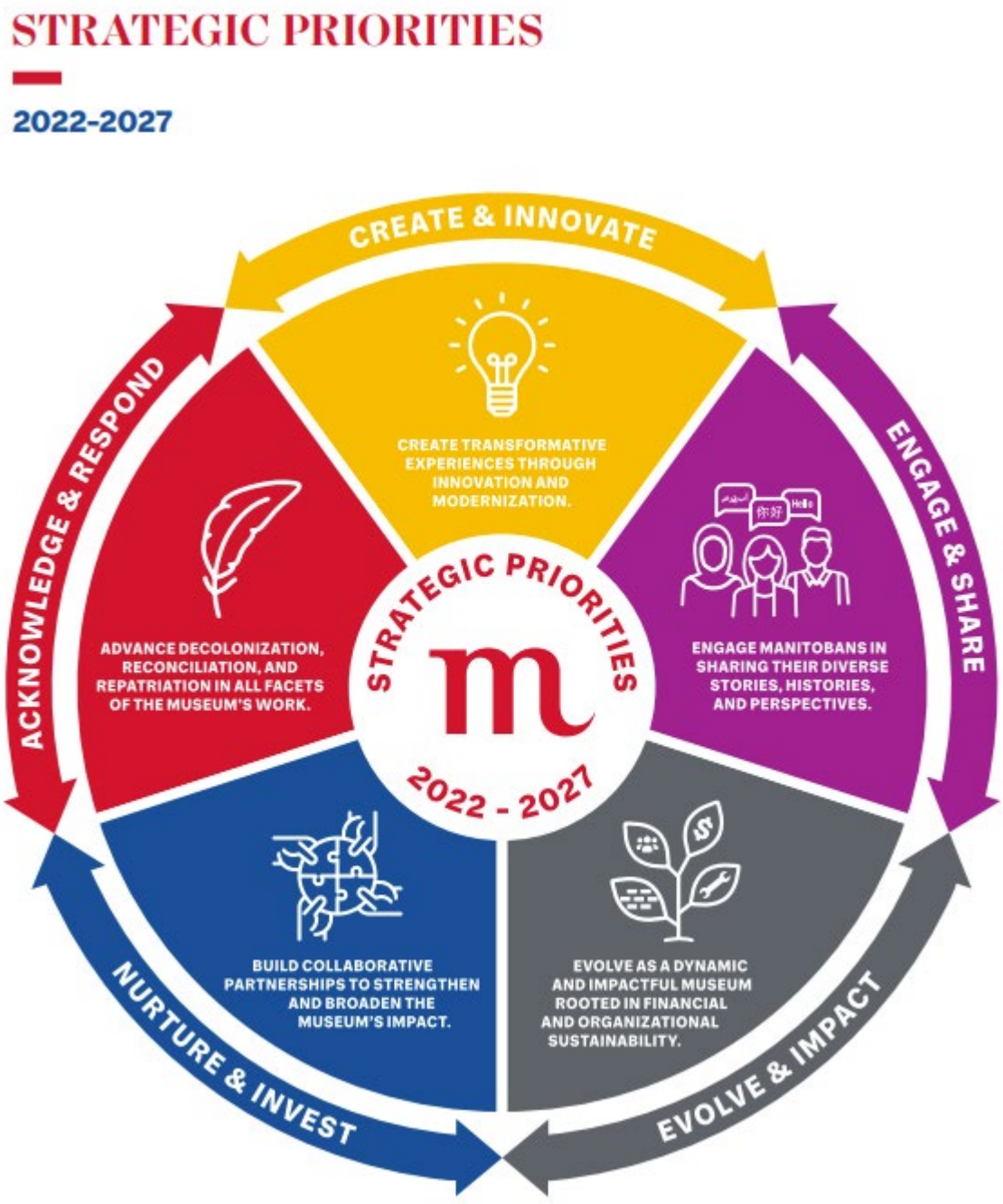
The Manitoba Museum needs to determine a plan that begins with their approach to blockbuster exhibitions and cascades into positive financial impacts for the organization. Consider the following: what is the right timing for the blockbuster exhibitions? What pricing model should the organization use for these major events? How many visitors are needed to sustain the financials of each exhibition, and how can the Museum attract those visitors? How can the Manitoba Museum capitalize on increased traffic during these exhibitions to sustain financial stability? How are comparable organizations across Canada managing similar financial challenges, and what can be applied in Manitoba?

Provide a comprehensive proposal to address the Museum's financial concerns and bring long-term stability to the programming offered.

For annual reports and financial statements, additional information is available on the Manitoba Museum website: https://manitobamuseum.ca/our-mission/annual-reports/.

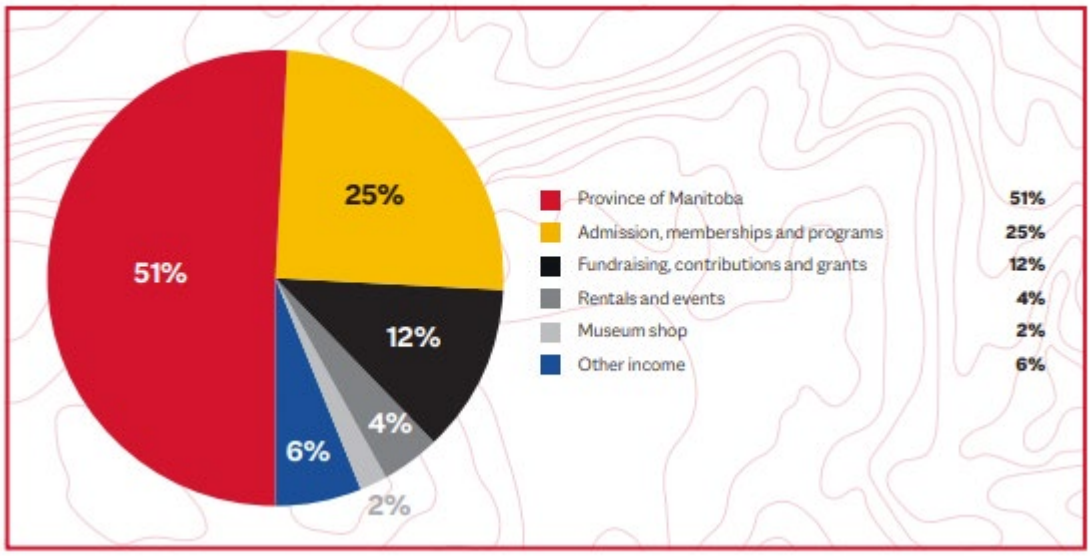
Please consult the competition rules provided to your team. You may (and should) conduct outside research and use other sources of information beyond those provided in the case. <u>However, teams are strictly prohibited from contacting or speaking with the Manitoba Museum's staff, partners, suppliers, or customers directly.</u>

Appendix A: Manitoba Museum Strategic Priorities

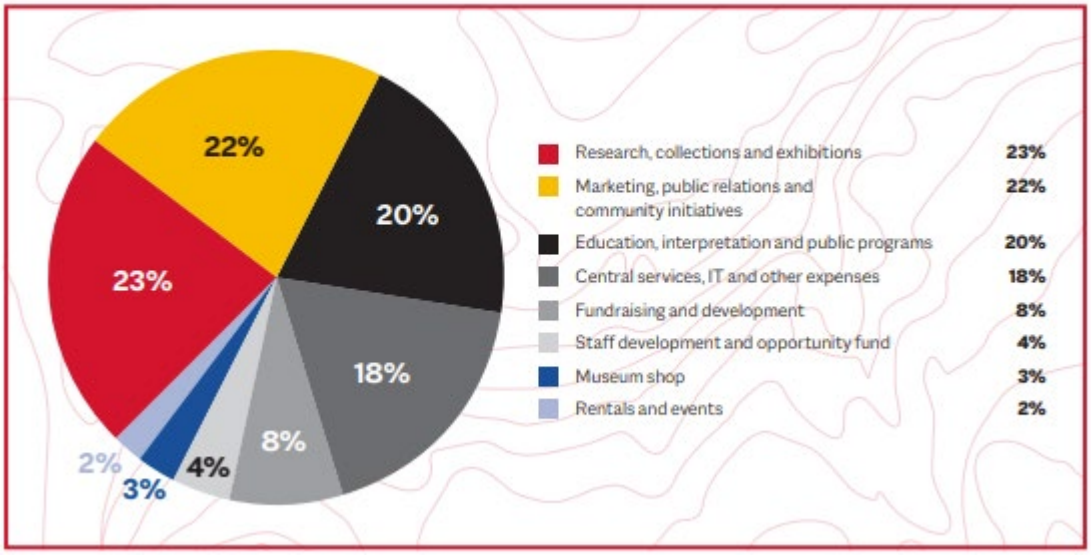


Appendix B: 2023-2024 Annual Report Revenue Sources and Expenses

REVENUE



EXPENSES



Appendix C: Pricing for Alloway Hall Exhibition: Ultimate Dinosaurs

[Admission to Ultimate Dinosaurs must be combined with a minimum of 1 museum area]

	Ultimate Dinosaurs Surcharge	Admission with 1 area	Admission with 2 areas	Admission with 3 areas
Adult (18-64)	$10.00	$22.00	$30.40	$35.20
Senior (65+)	$10.00	$20.00	$27.00	$31.00
Student (13-17 or with ID)	$10.00	$19.00	$25.30	$28.90
Child (3-12)	$8.00	$15.00	$19.90	$22.70
Member	$8.00	$8.00	$8.00	$8.00
School rate per child	$5.25			

Appendix D: Projected and Actual Revenue for Alloway Hall Exhibition: Ultimate Dinosaurs

	Projected Attendance	Average Surcharge	Estimated Revenue	Actual Attendance	Actual Revenue
All categories except schools	45,000	$9.25	$ 416,250.00	23,945	$ 221,491.25
Schools	3,000	$5.25	$ 15,750.00	3278	$ 17,209.50

Appendix E: Feedback Survey Responses

[link to survey responses spreadsheet]

Appendix F: Planned Pricing for Alloway Hall Exhibition in 2028

	Exhibition Surcharge	Admission with 1 area	Admission with 2 areas	Admission with 3 areas
Adult (18-64)	$15.00	$27.00	$35.40	$40.20
Senior (65+)	$13.00	$23.00	$30.00	$34.00
Student (13-17 or with ID)	$13.00	$12.00	$28.30	$31.90
Child (3-12)	$10.00	$17.00	$21.90	$24.70
Member	$10.00	$10.00	$10.00	$10.00
School rate per child	$7.25			

Appendix G: Alloway Hall Usage by Month

	Historic Exhibit Attendance	**Projected Potential Exhibit Value**	**Historic Rental Demand**	**Projected Potential Rental value**	**2022 – 2023* Exhibit Visitors**	**2019-2020** Exhibit Visitors**
APRIL	MID	$70,442.93	HIGH	$30,000.00	-	2,169
MAY	MID	$38,453.47	HIGH	$25,000.00	2,014	3,887
JUNE	LOW	$49,821.04	MID	$20,000.00	2,916	3,662
JULY	HIGH	$117,922.88	MID	$25,000.00	7,802	7,200
AUGUST	HIGH	$132,544.91	MID	$25,000.00	8,837	9,464
SEPTEMBER	LOW	$52,183.86	LOW	$10,000.00	2,376	1,872
OCTOBER	MID	$62,023.65	HIGH	$32,500.00	-	-
NOVEMBER	LOW	$41,124.12	HIGH	$32,500.00	-	-
DECEMBER	MID	$56,364.26	HIGH	$30,000.00	-	-
JANUARY	MID	$66,558.68	LOW	$15,000.00	-	-
FEBRUARY	MID	$69,416.09	LOW	$10,000.00	-	-
MARCH	HIGH	$132,207.68	MID	$20,000.00	-	-
					23,945	**28,254**
					*May 21 to Sept 5	**April 17 - Sept 5
					May = 10 days, Sept = 5 days	April =14 days, Sept = 5

Appendix H: Blockbuster Exhibition Timing

Year	Exhibit	Start	End
2013	**Wrapped: The Mummy of Pesed**	25-Oct-13	6-Apr-14
2014	**Real Pirates!**	17-Oct-14	17-Apr-15
2015	**National Geographic's Earth Explorers**	23-Oct-15	24-Apr-16
2016	*Alloway Hall closed for renovations*	-	-
2017	**World's Giant Dinosaurs**	19-May-17	4-Sep-17
2018	**Hockey**	4-Jul-18	Jan-19
2019	**Animal Inside Out**	16-Apr-19	2-Sep-19
2020	*COVID-19 pandemic*	-	-
2021	*COVID-19 pandemic*	-	-
2022	**Ultimate Dinosaurs**	5-May-22	5-Sep-22

Appendix I: Performance During Blockbuster Exhibition Run

	2013	2014	2015	2017	2018	2019
Visitors: Alloway Hall Exhibit	19,526	29,691	22,588	41,489	32,037	36,387
Visitors: Museum Gallery	37,329	32,785	31,849	44,367	44,432	41,401
Visitors: Planetarium	14,404	11,778	11,792	16,101	16,223	14,358
Visitors: Science Gallery	20,084	17,231	17,415	22,482	21,442	20,232
Temporary Exhibit Revenue	211,030	256,800	133,500	320,079	152,650	274,443
Temporary Exhibit Costs	294,372	628,000	498,000	401,282	377,785	328,844
Temporary Exhibit Profit/(Loss)	(83,342)	(371,200)	(364,500)	(81,203)	(225,135)	(54,401)
Shop Revenue ($)	88,126	84,234	94,192	138,866	135,714	110,848
Shop Profit ($)	45,833	44,558	48,857	80,054	71,141	58,552
Shop Profit Margin %	52	52.9	51.9	57.6	52.4	52.8

Appendix J: Selected Full Year Performance

	2013	2014	2015	2017	2018	2019
General Sponsorship ($)	158,705	155,235	182,580	169,478	181,678	112,062
Membership Revenue ($)	165,284	184,825	201,219	260,132	271,600	223,800
Number of Memberships	11,425	9,952	10,068	14,245	12,090	12,305
Rentals ($)	81,900	80,200	43,000	90,000	84,100	135,300
Shop Revenue ($)	168,543	165,962	184,412	266,113	217,789	170,944
Shop Expense ($)	152,059	175,958	205,598	225,536	226,367	182,849
Shop Net ($)	16,484	-9,996	-21,186	40,577	-8,578	-11,905

Appendix K: Membership Sales by Category

